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Children pull carts with mattresses as Palestinians fled Rafah towards Khan Younis in the southern Gaza Strip yesterday to escape the growing wave of attacks by the Israeli military.

Israel expanding offensive to seize 'large areas' of Gaza

Army 'dissecting' territory to retrieve hostages: PM

GAZA

Israel said yesterday it would expand its military operations and seize "large areas" of the Gaza Strip where rescuers said 34 people were killed in Israeli strikes, including on a UN building.

Defence Minister Israel Katz said Israel would bolster its military presence in the Palestinian territory to "destroy and clear the area of terrorists and terrorist infrastructure".

The operation would "seize large areas that will be incorporated into Israeli security zones", he said, without specifying how much territory.

Meanwhile, Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu said that the military is "dissecting" Gaza and "seizing territory" to retrieve hostages held in the Palestinian territory.

The military is "dissecting

US DEPLOYS SECOND AIRCRAFT CARRIER

Defence Secretary Pete Hegseth has ordered additional forces to the Middle East, including the *Carl Vinson* carrier strike group and aircraft, as the US vows to continue its strikes against Iran-backed Houthi militants and as tensions with Tehran are increasing over its nuclear programme.

The *Carl Vinson* will arrive in the region after completing exercises in the Indo-Pacific. The department is also prolonging the Harry S. Truman carrier strike group's deployment in the region, Pentagon spokesman Sean Parnell said in a statement Tuesday. The unusual two-carrier presence repeats a show of force by the Biden administration last year.

— AFP

the (Gaza) Strip and increasing the pressure step by step so that (Hamas) will return our hostages", Netanyahu said, adding that Israel "is seizing territory, striking terrorists, and destroying infrastructure".

Gaza's civil defence agency said at least 19 people were killed, including nine children, when an Israeli strike "targeted an UNRWA (UN agency for Palestinian refugees) building housing a medical clinic in Jabalia refugee camp".

The Israeli army said in a statement that it struck Hamas militants "inside a command and control centre" in north Gaza's Jabalia. It separately confirmed to AFP the building housed a UN clinic.

The Palestinian foreign ministry, based in the occupied West Bank, condemned the "massacre at the UNRWA clinic in Jabalia" and called for "serious international pressure" to halt Israel's widening offensive.

SEE ALSO P10

UAE global favourite for entrepreneurship

Country outperforms 55 economies for the fourth straight year

DUBAI

BY KHITAM ALAMIR
Chief News Editor

The UAE has once again solidified its position as the world's top destination for entrepreneurship, ranking first globally in the Global Entrepreneurship Monitor (GEM) report for the fourth consecutive year.

The country outperformed 55 economies, excelling in key indicators such as entrepreneurial financing, government support, and ease of market entry.

The UAE continues to foster a thriving entrepreneurial ecosystem, integrating business-friendly policies, tax incentives, and regulatory reforms. Minister of State for Entrepreneurship, Alia Ab-

\$8.7b

UAE's investment to foster entrepreneurship, alongside policies like 100% foreign ownership

dulla Al Mazrouei, emphasised that the nation's commitment to innovation and SME growth has propelled it to global prominence.

Boosting confidence

A key factor driving this success is the UAE's \$8.7 billion investment in fostering entrepreneurship, alongside policies like 100 per cent foreign ownership, which have boosted investor confidence. With record-breaking foreign direct investment (FDI) and an ambitious vision for one million SMEs by 2031, the UAE is reinforcing its status as a global hub for business and innovation.

Dubai's largest driverless taxi rollout next year

INDUSTRY GIANTS UBER, BAIDU'S APOLLO GO AND WERIDE JOIN FORCES WITH RTA

DUBAI

BY DHANUSHA GOKULAN
Chief Reporter
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Chief Reporter



Dubai is gearing up for a major shift in urban mobility as a new fleet of self-driving taxis prepares to hit the roads next year. The Roads and Transport Authority (RTA) has announced an expansion of its partnerships with leading autonomous vehicle developers, setting the stage for the city's largest autonomous mobility rollout yet.

A pilot phase will begin later this year, with safety drivers on-board, paving the way for a fully driverless commercial launch in 2026. This initiative aligns with Dubai's Self-Driving Transport Strategy, which aims to make 25 per cent of all citywide trips autonomous by 2030.

Industry giants Uber, WeRide, and Baidu's Apollo Go have joined forces with RTA to develop and deploy autonomous ride-hailing services in Dubai. WeRide and Uber will collaborate on testing programmes, integrating Uber's ride-matching technology with WeRide's robotaxis. Meanwhile, Baidu's Apollo Go, China's largest autonomous ride-hailing platform, is making its debut in Dubai as part of its most ambitious overseas expansion to date.

Dubai's growing reputation

WeRide and Uber will collaborate on testing programmes, integrating Uber's ride-matching technology with WeRide's robotaxis.

as a hub for autonomous mobility has attracted multiple AV operators. WeRide launched its first robotaxis in Abu Dhabi in 2021 and secured the UAE's first national driverless permit in 2023, covering all types of AVs. Autogo, another autonomous mobility company, has also begun trials in Abu Dhabi, with plans to launch services next year.

Massive rollout

Dubai's entry into large-scale self-driving taxis follows a previous agreement between RTA and Cruise, the General Motors-owned AV company, which introduced Chevrolet Bolt-based robotaxis in 2023. The self-driving taxi fares are expected to be around 30 per cent higher than standard taxis, comparable to limousine services.

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NATION

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